completing the conquest and handing the castle over, Saladin withdrew and allowed the Christian enemy to stay in place. Ibn al-Athir tells us that he was afraid to clear Nur ad-Din's path to Egypt: "If Nur ad-Din comes to you here," one of Saladin's officers says, ". . . he will exercise his authority over you. . . . [I]f he wishes, he will dismiss you and you will be unable to resist."

Saladin returned to Egypt and wrote to Nur ad-Din, excusing himself on the grounds that he feared a coup was developing in his absence. Nur ad-Din was not fooled. "His attitude towards him changed," Ibn al-Athir writes, "and he resolved to enter Egypt and expel him."[2]

But before Nur ad-Din could bring Saladin to heel, he was struck with quinsy: a throat abscess, caused by tonsillitis, which precipitated a massive infection and shut his body down. He died in Damascus, refusing treatment. ("A sixty-year-old," he snapped at his doctor, "is not to be bled.") He left his kingdom to his eleven-year-old son, al-Salih Ismail.[3]

Now Saladin took the offensive. He rode north and entered Damascus as al-Salih's protector and guardian: "Aware that [Nur ad-Din's] son was a child . . . incapable of taking on the defense of the lands against God's enemies," his biographer explains, "he made his preparations to march to Syria, since it is the cornerstone of Muslim territory."[4]

For a year or so, Saladin acted as al-Salih's general and regent. His presence in the boy's kingdom was not a peaceful one; al-Salih himself appealed to his subjects to eject the usurper. ("This wicked man, who repudiates my father's goodness to him, has come to take my lands," he told the men of Aleppo, who obediently rebelled.) But Saladin's Egyptian troops quelled revolt after revolt. After a victory against the combined armies of Aleppo and Mosul in April of 1175, Saladin decreed that his own name should be substituted for young al-Salih's in the Friday prayers. No more coins were to be struck in al-Salih's name. In May, the Abbasid caliph in Baghdad, which Saladin now controlled, prudently declared Saladin to be Sultan of Egypt and Syria; a letter sent to the caliph by Saladin's secretary Qadi al-Fadil explained that only Saladin was strong enough to protect Nur ad-Din's accomplishments, and that his "sole purpose" was to keep the Islamic cause unified and strong.[5]

The next few years saw Saladin doing just that. He married Nur ad-Din's widow, some ten years his senior, and laid claim to his predecessor's lands. He fought rebellious Muslim governors and encroaching Crusader armies; when politic, he made treaties with the Crusaders instead. He set up a formal Office of the Navy and channeled a good deal of revenue into building additional ships to bulk up the Egyptian fleet. In 1181, young al-Salih died of